

THE DARKNESS HIERARCHY

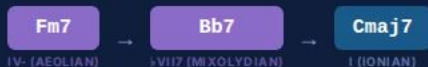
Seven modes arranged from brightest (Lydian) to darkest (Phrygian). Locrian is marked unusable. Each column shows the mode's characteristic note and most useful borrowed chords.

THE MODAL SPECTRUM — BRIGHTEST TO DARKEST

LYDIAN ETHEREAL #4	IONIAN BASELINE Major	MIXO-LYDIAN BLUESY b7	DORIAN DARK+HOPE nat. 6	AEOLIAN NATURAL MINOR b6	PHRYGIAN DARKEST b2	LOCRIAN x UNUSABLE b5
II (D) Bright lift, also V7/V #ivø7 Dark contrast from bright	I-vii° All 7 diatonic chords (home base) Nothing borrowed here	bVII (Bb) Rock/blues feel v-7 Soft minor dominant	IV (D) Bright in minor key IV7 (D7) Even brighter color	bVI (Ab) Epic, cinematic iv- (Fm) Dark subdominant	bII (Db) Exotic, dramatic bIImaj7 Lush dark exotic	— Unstable tonic, no usable chords — Avoid for borrowing

The borrowing rule: only borrow chords that CONTAIN the mode's characteristic note. Borrowing a chord that lacks the characteristic note adds no modal color — it's just a regular diatonic chord that doesn't signal the mode you're borrowing from.

THE BACKDOOR II-V — DARK MODE SUMMARY IN C MAJOR



The Backdoor ii-V uses borrowed chords from parallel minor (Fm7 from Aeolian, Bb7 from Mixolydian/Aeolian overlap) to arrive at the major tonic. The chromatic bass motion F → Bb → C creates a warm, inevitable feeling that's softer than the traditional ii-V-I but equally conclusive. This is the parallel-minor equivalent of the ii-V-I journey.